> claimed and taken over by the native at the moment when deciding to embody history in his own person, he surges into the forbidden quarters.[4]

And indeed, it is precisely this violence that Bhagat Singh puts into practical effect by assassinating J.P. Saunders. What Fanon was here putting in writing as a political philosophy had already been put into practical operation by Bhagat Singh. To that extent there is a moral necessity in the violence of Bhagat Singh and his comrades. If the Indian masses had united in a violent overthrow of their colonial subjugation there is every reason to believe that Hindus, Muslims and Sikhs would today be living together in one united country rather than in separate individual enclaves. This is why Fanon considered anti-colonial violence so important as he wrote that 'the native's violence unites the people. By its very structure, colonisation is separatist and regionalist. Colonialism does not simply state the existence of the tribes; it also reinforces it and separates them'. However, '[a]t the level of individuals, violence is a cleansing force. It frees the native from his inferiority complex and from his despair and inaction; it makes him fearless and restores his self-respect'.[5] It is this 'cleansing force' of the violence in the assassination of J.P. Saunders that has come to be applauded by those opposed to colonial rule in India. In the process, it has obscured the difference between the act of avenging and the person on whose behalf it was undertaken. It is time to set the record straight.

The extent of Bhagat Singh's disagreement with Lala Lajpat Rai is intriguing, in that although Bhagat Singh revered Lajpat Rai as a leader of the militant nationalist freedom movement in his own right, he did not always see eye-to-eye with him. Indeed, a number of his disagreements were fundamental. They went to the core of how the fight for freedom should be fought. For one thing, Bhagat Singh could not agree with Lajpat Rai 'that India should be divided into two countries: Hindu India and Muslim India'. This is because Hindus and Muslims had lived together 'side by side in thousands of towns, villages, and hamlets for hundreds of years' and 'they shared each other's sorrow and happiness, heritage and history'. In fact, 'they toiled together and suffered together' such that 'the